

# Gauntlet v0.6.3 Reference Guide

**Status:** Release candidate — not published

**Version:** v0.6.3

## Setup

**Faction setup → Draw 4 / discard 1 / keep 3 → arrange Territories → form and reveal Gauntlet → place tokens → roll first player**

- Shuffle the remaining Deck to form the Draw Pile after faction setup.
- Arrange Territories with the opening Hand and face-up opening discard known.
- Each token starts on the Territory at its player's own end; setup placement is neither movement nor entering.
- Roll for first player only after both players complete opening selection and Territory arrangement.

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## Run the Gauntlet

Win immediately by either:

- capturing the Territory at your opponent's end; or
- winning your opponent's Last Stand.

After forcing the opponent beyond their end, a **separate legal movement sequence** may Advance beyond the Gauntlet and initiate the Last Stand. You do not need to control the final Territory first.

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## Your Turn

**Capture → Draw → Opening → Movement → Denouement → Cleanup**

### Capture

If your token is beyond your **Front Line**, capture the next opposing Territory immediately beyond that line.

- Your controlled Territories must remain contiguous from your own end.
- Your position may extend beyond your control.
- Normal Capture advances your Front Line by at most one Territory per turn.

### Draw

Draw one card.

### Opening

You may take your Action now.

## Movement

Choose one:

- **Advance:** move one position toward the opponent's end.
- **Hold:** remain where you are.
- **Fall Back:** move one position toward your own end.

Entering the opponent's position creates a pending battle and ends the current movement sequence.

## Denouement

You may take your Action now if you did not take it during Opening.

## Cleanup

Resolve end-of-turn effects and discard down to the Hand limit. Pass the active-player marker.

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## Card use reminder

Cards may print **Action**, **Asset**, **Gambit**, **Tactic**, or **Gambit/Tactic** effects. A card with an Asset effect has an inherent Bank Action unless it prints a special banking procedure.

## Actions

Each turn, normally take **one Action** during either Opening or Denouement.

An Action may:

- play one card for its **Action** effect;
- bank one card from Hand using its inherent **Bank** Action if it has an Asset effect;
- take one legal **Faction Action**; or
- discard one of your Assets.

Normally take no more than one Action during either phase.

An additional Action does not by itself permit two Actions during the same phase.

A **Faction Action** lists the phase in which it is legal.

A **Faction Ability** occurs at its stated timing and does not use an Action unless it says otherwise.

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## Pending Battle and Terms

**Pending battle → Terms → Onset → Gambits**

Before Onset:

1. establish the attacker, defender, contested position, and the attacker's previous position;
2. resolve the Terms timing if a Diplomat is involved; and
3. proceed according to the decision.

## Accepted Terms

Apply the Proposal's Accepted effect. No battle begins.

Unless the Proposal says otherwise:

**The attacker withdraws. The defender remains at the contested position.**

No Onset, Gambit, Reserve, Tactic, Outcome, or Aftermath occurs.

## Refused or no Terms

Proceed to **Onset**.

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# Battle

**Onset → set Gambits → form Reserves → reveal Gambits → choose Tactics → reveal Tactics → Outcome → Aftermath**

## Onset

Onset begins the battle. Resolve Onset effects before Gambits are set.

## Outcome

The higher battle total wins.

## Defensive Edge

**Defensive Edge: When the defender has Defensive Edge, the defender wins tied battle totals.**

The defender normally has Defensive Edge when:

- the defender controls the contested Territory; or
- the defender is making a Last Stand.

An effect may remove Defensive Edge, including an applicable Arena Territory effect.

## Tiebreak Roll

If the tie remains unresolved:

**Each player rolls one die. Do not apply advantage, disadvantage, card effects, numerical modifiers, or the previous battle totals. Higher roll wins. Reroll further ties.**

Only an effect that expressly refers to a **Tiebreak Roll** may modify it.

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# Retreat and Withdrawal

**A losing player retreats; a player who leaves without losing withdraws.**

Retreat and withdrawal normally move a player the same way:

- attacker: return to the position from which they entered;
- defender: move one position toward their own end;
- only the attacker withdraws: the defender remains in the contested position;
- only the defender withdraws: the attacker remains in the contested position and becomes the occupier when applicable;

- both withdraw: move the attacker first, then the defender; neither becomes the occupier because of the withdrawal.

## Retreat

- follows a battle loss;
- the battle has a winner and loser;
- win, loss, retreat, Occupation, and other result effects apply.

## Withdrawal

- ends or prevents a pending or active battle without a winner;
- win, loss, and retreat effects do not occur;
- before Onset: no battle or Aftermath occurs;
- after Onset: complete the remaining non-result steps of the Aftermath and clear any committed battle cards using their normal destinations.

**Fall Back** is ordinary Movement. It is neither retreat nor withdrawal.

## Front Line

Your **Front Line** is the unbroken sequence of Territories you control from your own end.

- Control cannot skip an opposing Territory.
- Your token may move beyond your Front Line.
- During Capture, add the next opposing Territory immediately beyond your Front Line if your token is on or beyond it.
- The captured Territory may be behind your token.
- Deep Position alone does not capture the final Territory. Last Stand access instead requires a new legal Advance beyond the opponent's end after that opponent is beyond the Gauntlet.

## Core Vocabulary

| Term            | Meaning                                                                          |
|-----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Opening         | Action phase before Movement.                                                    |
| Denouement      | Action phase after Movement and any resulting battle.                            |
| Faction Action  | Faction-specific option chosen when taking an Action; lists its legal phase.     |
| Faction Ability | Faction-specific effect at its own timing; does not use an Action unless stated. |
| Fall Back       | Ordinary Movement one position toward your own end.                              |
| Pending battle  | Pre-battle state before Onset.                                                   |
| Onset           | Opening stage of an active battle.                                               |
| Aftermath       | Closing stage of an active battle.                                               |
| Defensive Edge  | Conditional benefit that causes the defender to win tied battle totals.          |
| Tiebreak Roll   | Separate unmodified one-die sudden-death roll.                                   |
| Front Line      | Contiguous controlled Territories from your own end.                             |
| Retreat         | Displacement after losing a battle.                                              |
| Withdraw        | Leave or prevent a battle without determining a winner.                          |

# Gauntlet v0.6.3 First Game and Tableside Guide

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## 1. First-game teaching order

Teach in three layers:

1. **The shared game** — the turn, Movement, one ordinary battle, Occupation, Capture, and running the Gauntlet.
2. **Your faction** — its resource or progression, Leader, Faction Actions and Abilities, and additional victory.
3. **The opponent's faction** — only the public information needed to make decisions against it.

Do not begin by reading both complete faction guides aloud. Each player receives one authoritative tableside faction reference for their own faction and one concise opponent summary for the opposing faction.

### Before faction rules

Physically demonstrate:

1. one ordinary turn;
2. one ordinary battle with Hand, Gambit, Reserve, and Tactic visibly separated;
3. Fall Back, withdrawal, and retreat as three different movements;
4. an attacker becoming the occupier after winning;
5. Capture advancing the Front Line on a later turn; and
6. a bound card placed beneath the effect that binds it.

Only after this shared demonstration should each player learn their faction overlay.

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## 2. Setup for v0.6.3

1. Prepare faction and Leader components that can add cards to or remove cards from the Deck.
2. Shuffle the remaining Deck to form the Draw Pile.
3. Draw four cards, discard one face up, and keep three as the opening Hand.
4. With that Hand and opening discard known, secretly arrange your three Territories.
5. Join and reveal both Territory lines to form the Gauntlet.
6. Place each Player Token on the Territory at that player's own end. This is not movement and does not count as entering.
7. Only after both players finish opening selection and Territory arrangement, roll for first player.

### Running the Gauntlet

There are two normal victory routes: **capture the Territory at your opponent's end** or **win your opponent's Last Stand**. Either runs the Gauntlet and wins immediately. A separate legal movement sequence can initiate a Last Stand after the opponent is forced beyond their end; prior capture of the final Territory is not required.

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### 3. Shared tableside turn reference

Capture → Draw → Opening → Movement → Denouement → Cleanup

#### Capture

If the active player's token is on or beyond the next opposing Territory immediately beyond their Front Line, add that Territory to their Front Line.

- Control remains contiguous from the player's own end.
- Position may extend beyond control.
- Normal Capture advances the Front Line by at most one Territory.

#### Draw

Draw one card.

#### Opening

The active player may take their Action now.

#### Movement

Choose one:

- **Advance:** move one Position toward the opponent's end;
- **Hold:** remain in the current Position; or
- **Fall Back:** move one Position toward the active player's own end.

Entering the opponent's Position creates a pending battle and ends the current Movement sequence.

#### Denouement

The active player may take their Action now if they did not take it during Opening.

#### Cleanup

Resolve end-of-turn effects, discard down to the Hand limit, and pass the active-player marker.

#### Action reminder

A player normally takes one Action during either Opening or Denouement.

An Action may:

- play a card for its Action effect;
- bank a card from Hand using its inherent Bank Action if it has an Asset effect;
- take a legal Faction Action; or
- discard one of the player's Assets.

An additional Action does not by itself permit two Actions in one phase.

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## 4. Shared tableside battle reference

### Pending battle

Pending battle → Terms → Onset → Gambits

1. Establish attacker, defender, contested Position, and the attacker's previous Position.
2. Resolve Terms if a Diplomat is involved.
3. Accepted Terms prevent the battle.
4. Refused Terms or no Terms proceed to Onset.

### Active battle

Onset → set Gambits → form Reserves → reveal Gambits → choose Tactics → reveal Tactics → Outcome → Aftermath

#### Onset

Resolve effects used during Onset before Gambits are set.

**Before you commit cards to a battle, look beyond your Hand. Read the contested Territory and scan your Asset Bank. Those effects are easy to overlook once Gambits, Reserves, and Tactics begin, and some may matter at different points in the battle. Check when each effect can be used before you act.**

#### Gambit

Each player may set one eligible card from Hand face down. The card is no longer in Hand while it is in battle.

#### Reserve

Each player normally draws three cards into a temporary private Reserve.

#### Tactic

Each player may normally choose one eligible card from Reserve. Cards left in Reserve remain separate from Hand.

#### Outcome

Apply active effects, roll, and compare battle totals.

- When the defender has **Defensive Edge**, the defender wins tied battle totals.
- If the tie remains unresolved, make a separate unmodified **Tiebreak Roll**.
- Higher Tiebreak Roll wins; reroll further ties.

#### Aftermath

Apply the result, retreat the loser, establish Occupation when applicable, resolve Aftermath effects, and clear battle cards to their normal destinations.

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## 5. Movement and result diagram

Use this verbal and visual distinction on every player reference:

**Fall Back is ordinary Movement. A losing player retreats. A player who leaves without losing withdraws.**

## Fall Back

- chosen during the active player's normal Movement;
- moves one Position toward that player's own end;
- does not involve a battle result.

## Retreat

- follows a battle loss;
- creates a winner and loser;
- triggers win, loss, retreat, and Occupation consequences.

## Withdrawal

- ends or prevents a pending or active battle without a winner;
- triggers no win, loss, or retreat effects;
- before Onset, produces no battle or Aftermath;
- after Onset, completes the remaining non-result Aftermath and clears committed cards normally.

## Occupation and Capture

1. An attacker wins on an opposing controlled Territory.
  2. The defender retreats.
  3. The attacker remains and becomes the **occupier**.
  4. Control does not change yet.
  5. If the attacker remains on or beyond the next Territory beyond their Front Line until a later Capture step, that Territory joins the Front Line.
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# 6. Player-mat and zone specification

Each player mat must provide clearly separated labeled areas for:

- Draw Pile;
- Hand;
- Discard Pile;
- Graveyard;
- Asset Bank;
- Leader and faction components;
- Gambit;
- Reserve;
- Tactic;
- current Territory / Player Token relationship; and
- temporary bound cards.

The Hand remains the player's permanent private cards. Reserve is a separate temporary private zone used only during the current battle.

## Battle-zone layout

Arrange battle zones in play order:

**Hand → Gambit | Reserve → Tactic**



The Gambit area should sit between the Hand and battle center. The Reserve and Tactic areas should be visibly separate so an unchosen Reserve card cannot be mistaken for a Tactic or Hand card.

## Faction areas

- **Military:** Leader and Command tracker.
- **Diplomats:** Leader, Influence tracker, Proposal row, and ratified Treaty Articles.
- **Financiers:** Leader, Capital ledger, Treasury, and owned Deeds.
- **Intelligence:** Leader, Intel, Operation Progress, Active Mission or Special Operation.
- **Mystics:** Leader, three Rites, Ritual area, and bound-card spaces.
- **Inquisition:** Leader, Conviction tracker, doctrine, and Purge reference.

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## 7. Bound-card diagram and reminder

A bound card is physically tucked beneath or placed immediately beside the effect that binds it, with enough of the card visible to identify it when public.

**BOUND — outside Hand, Draw Pile, Discard Pile, Graveyard, Reserve, Tactic, and Asset Bank**

- A face-up bound card is public.
- A face-down bound card may be inspected only by its owner.
- It cannot be played, moved, or affected except by the effect to which it is bound.
- The binding effect determines where it goes when the binding ends.

For Mystics Rites and the Ritual, the mat should show dedicated slots beneath the relevant Rite or Ritual reference. For Extraordinary Rendition, place the selected opposing card face up beneath the Asset.

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## 8. Active-player marker

The active-player marker is a shared physical object passed after Cleanup.

### Required face text

**YOUR TURN**

**Capture → Draw → Opening → Movement → Denouement → Cleanup**

### Required reminder text

- Take one Action during Opening or Denouement.
- Pass this marker after Cleanup.

The marker tracks only whose turn it is and the shared turn sequence. It does not track battle initiative, priority, Actions remaining, or the attacker.

Its final illustration, shape, stock, and production form remain open for the release-production pass.

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## 9. Faction teaching cards

Each faction reference uses the same order:

1. aim;

2. resource or progression;
3. Faction Actions;
4. Faction Abilities and public timing windows;
5. additional victory;
6. Leader comparison;
7. recommended starter Deck;
8. first-turn plan; and
9. opponent summary.

## Military

### Your faction

- **Aim:** Win battles, gain Command, and convert momentum into movement and control.
- **Resource:** Command, maximum 2. Gain 1 the first time each turn Military wins a battle.
- **Faction Actions:** None.
- **Faction Abilities:** Orders at their printed timings.
- **Additional victory:** None; Military runs the Gauntlet.
- **General:** Attacks repeatedly and carries momentum forward.
- **Commandant:** Defends controlled ground and turns defensive wins into pressure.
- **Recommended first Leader:** General.
- **Starter Decks:** Forward Doctrine / Holdfast.

### Opponent summary

Track Command. Military may add movement, modify a battle, push a retreat farther, or advance its Front Line after a win. Invasion can enlarge an attacking Reserve and Tactic limit, but unused Invasion movement ends when a pending battle is created.

## Diplomats

### Your faction

- **Aim:** Offer Terms, ratify different Proposals, and reshape battles through agreement or refusal.
- **Resource:** Influence, 0–10; begin with 1.
- **Faction Actions:** None.
- **Faction procedure:** Offer Terms during a pending battle before Onset.
- **Faction Ability:** Leverage after refused Terms before dice.
- **Additional victory:** Peace Treaty after five different Proposals are ratified.
- **Ambassador:** Gains card flow from accepted Terms.
- **Senator:** Risks larger Stakes and preserves Influence after setbacks.
- **Recommended first Leader:** Ambassador.
- **Starter Decks:** Open Channels / Procedure Endures.

### Opponent summary

Read the Proposal before accepting or refusing. Accepted Terms prevent the battle; refusal proceeds to Onset. The Diplomat gains more Influence by imposing a newly ratified Proposal after a win, and Détente rewards acceptance only when the Proposal was already ratified when offered.

## Financiers

### Your faction

- **Aim:** Build Capital and Treasury value, buy Deeds, and combine ownership with territorial pressure.
- **Resource:** Capital; begin with 2.

- **Faction Actions:** Treasury, Deed purchase, Play the Market, and Hostile Takeover during Denouement.
- **Faction Ability:** Subsidize before dice; Financial Capacity may permit an Action in both Opening and Denouement.
- **Additional victory:** Own the Deeds to every Territory through Controlling Interest.
- **Banker:** Uses cards as controlled collateral for purchases.
- **Executive:** Converts offensive Occupation into Deed ownership and Front Line control.
- **Recommended first Leader:** Executive.
- **Starter Decks:** Sound Investment / Hostile Expansion.

### Opponent summary

Capital, Treasury, and Deeds are public. Financial Capacity may give the Financier both Action phases, provided one Action is a Financier Faction Action. Deed ownership does not itself equal Territory control.

## Intelligence

### Your faction

- **Aim:** Complete Missions, gain Intel and Operation Progress, and prepare a Special Operation.
- **Resources:** Intel and Operation Progress.
- **Faction Actions:** Start, complete, or abort a Mission; start or complete a Special Operation, all during Denouement.
- **Faction Abilities:** Surveillance, Interference, Fieldcraft, and Mission Control at their stated timings.
- **Additional victory:** Complete a ready Special Operation.
- **Ranger:** Uses Fieldcraft and terrain knowledge for flexible operations.
- **Spymaster:** Chains Missions through Mission Control.
- **Recommended first Leader:** Ranger.
- **Starter Decks:** Field Operations / Mission Network.

### Opponent summary

Mission identity is hidden, but Intel and Operation Progress are public. Intelligence may reveal and interfere with a face-down Gambit and later with face-down Tactics. Replacements do not create a new information window.

## Mystics

### Your faction

- **Aim:** Complete three Rites, unlock Invocation, Transmutation, and Convergence, then complete the Ritual of Ascendance.
- **Progression:** Three public Rites; no resource tracker.
- **Faction Actions:** Begin a Rite or begin the Ritual during Denouement, except Nature's Altar may permit Begin a Rite during Opening.
- **Faction Abilities:** Rite completion, Invocation, Transmutation, Convergence, and Leader abilities.
- **Additional victory:** Initiate and win a battle while the three Ritual cards remain bound.
- **Alchemist:** Replaces deliberate sacrifice with card flow.
- **Spirit Walker:** Protects Rite and Ritual progress after a loss.
- **Recommended first Leader:** Spirit Walker.
- **Starter Decks:** First Principles / Unbroken Circle.

### Opponent summary

Completed Rites and bound cards are public when face up. The Spirit Walker may prevent interruption by sacrificing an Arcane card with value 1, 2, 3, or 4 according to progress. Nature's Altar requires token presence to begin and control at completion timing for its same-turn exception.

# Inquisition

## Your faction

- **Aim:** Build Conviction, move opposing cards permanently into the Graveyard, and use Purge to remove options.
- **Resource:** Conviction, maximum 4.
- **Faction Action:** Purge during Opening or Denouement. A Purge Action permits one Action in each phase, provided one is Purge.
- **Faction Abilities:** Condemnation, Blasphemy, Final Judgment, and Relentless Pursuit.
- **Additional victory:** Purification when the opponent cannot make the normal start-of-turn draw because both Draw Pile and Discard Pile are empty.
- **Grand Inquisitor:** Converts battle wins into discounted Purges.
- **Witch Hunter:** Punishes failed attacks with immediate pursuit.
- **Recommended first Leader:** Grand Inquisitor.
- **Starter Decks:** Final Judgment / Relentless Pursuit.

## Opponent summary

Opposing Tactics normally go to the Graveyard in battles against Inquisition. Track Conviction before playing Arcane cards or attacking the Witch Hunter. Martyrdom does not prevent a loss, but it can send cards remaining in the winner's Reserve to the Graveyard.

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## 10. Introductory pairings

### Preferred first pairing

**Military — General vs Inquisition — Grand Inquisitor**

Why:

- both players use the shared battle game directly;
- both resources are public and capped;
- neither player must learn hidden objectives or negotiation procedure first;
- each Leader demonstrates a clear win-to-resource loop; and
- the matchup teaches Graveyard consequences without requiring a second board subsystem.

### Alternative first pairings

- **Military — Commandant vs Financiers — Executive:** defense and Occupation against direct acquisition.
- **Diplomats — Ambassador vs Military — General:** introduces Terms against an otherwise direct opponent.
- **Intelligence — Ranger vs Inquisition — Grand Inquisitor:** introduces hidden information while keeping the opposing faction public.

### Pairings to reserve for a guided host

- Intelligence vs Mystics;
- Diplomats vs Intelligence;
- Financiers mirror;
- Diplomats mirror; and
- any pairing where both players are simultaneously learning hidden objectives, extensive interrupts, or alternate-victory sequencing.

These are teaching recommendations, not balance judgments or restrictions.

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## 11. Five-minute guided first battle

Before beginning the actual game:

1. Place both Player Tokens together on a sample contested Territory.
2. Name an attacker and defender.
3. Skip Terms unless demonstrating Diplomats.
4. Announce **Onset**.
5. Each player takes any one card from the top of their Deck and places it face down as a sample Gambit.
6. Each player takes three more cards as a sample Reserve.
7. Each chooses one sample Tactic.
8. Reveal the sample Gambits and Tactics without applying printed effects.
9. Roll and identify whether Defensive Edge or a Tiebreak Roll would apply.
10. Demonstrate the loser's retreat, the attacker's Occupation when applicable, and the normal card destinations.
11. Return all demonstration cards, shuffle both Decks, reset the tokens, and begin normal setup draws.

This dry run teaches physical zones and result movement without altering the actual game or requiring players to understand four unfamiliar card effects at once.

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## 12. Starter Deck presentation

For each recommended first-game Deck, present:

- Deck name;
- Leader and faction;
- one-sentence plan;
- Opening plan;
- four signature cards;
- Territory order from the player's own end outward;
- first-game tip;
- opponent watch text; and
- exact 30-card list and 60-value total.

Do not describe the starter as a reduced card pool. It is a coherent recommended Deck built from the full legal pool.

The v0.6.3 development Deckbuilder and `/v0.6.3/start/` flow use the v0.6.3 candidate data and adapted starter catalog.

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## 13. Authority and release boundary

For the v0.6.3 release candidate:

1. The v0.6.3 Rulebook candidate and specific component text govern candidate play and review.
2. `Gauntlet_v0.6.3_Starter_Decks.json` governs the twelve recommended starter compositions in the assembled source candidate.
3. This document governs v0.6.3 first-game and tableside candidate presentation.
4. v0.6.2 remains the immutable published playtest release until the publication cutover is completed.

Later layout work may change typography, iconography, dimensions, and illustration, but it may not change the sequences, terminology, faction summaries, or starter compositions without a recorded superseding decision.

# Player Mat

Player \_\_\_\_\_  
Faction \_\_\_\_\_ Leader \_\_\_\_\_

**YOUR TURN: Capture - Draw - Opening - Movement - Denouement - Cleanup**  
Take one Action during Opening or Denouement. Pass the active-player marker after Cleanup.

Hand

Permanent private cards

Begin with 3. During Cleanup, discard down to the normal Hand limit.

Draw Pile

Face down

Discard

Recyclable

Graveyard

Normally permanent

Bound Cards

Outside normal zones

Tuck each card beneath or beside the effect that binds it. A bound card cannot be played, moved, or affected except by that effect.

Position & Front Line

Token location is not control

Start on your own-end Territory; setup placement is not movement or entering. Front Line = contiguous Territories you control from your end. Capture the next opposing Territory when eligible.

Battle Staging

Clear after each active battle

Pending Battle / Onset

Terms occur before Onset

Establish attacker, defender, contested Position, and attack origin. Accepted Terms prevent the battle. Refused or no Terms proceed to Onset.

Fall Back  
ordinary Movement

Retreat  
after losing

Withdraw  
leave without a winner

Gambit

From Hand

Normally set up to one face down after Onset.

Aftermath: Graveyard

Tactic

From Reserve

Normally choose up to one after Gambits resolve.

Aftermath: Discard Pile

Reserve

Temporary private zone

Set Hand physically aside. Normally draw 3 cards here. Unchosen Reserve cards remain separate from Hand and go to the Discard Pile during Aftermath.

1 Onset

2 Set Gambits

3 Form Reserves

4 Reveal Gambits

5 Choose Tactics

6 Reveal Tactics

7 Outcome

8 Aftermath

Leader & Faction

Public components

Keep the Leader and faction trackers, references, Proposals, Deeds, Missions, Rites, doctrine, or other public components visible here.

Asset Bank

Public persistent cards

Limit equals Territories you control. When full, discard a controlled Asset to make room unless a rule prevents it from leaving.

Action Reminder

1 Action · Opening or Denouement

During Opening or Denouement: play one Action effect, take one legal Faction Action, or discard one Asset. An additional Action does not itself permit two Actions in one phase.

Outcome Reminder

Resolve ties correctly

Defensive Edge lets the defender win tied battle totals. If the tie remains, make a separate unmodified Tiebreak Roll; reroll further ties.

Occupation & Capture

Control changes later

Capturing the opponent-end Territory wins immediately. Once the opponent is beyond the Gauntlet, a separate legal Advance beyond their end can start a Last Stand without prior capture.

# Gauntlet Playtest Sheet

Record what happened before proposing a fix. One unusual game is evidence, not a verdict.

SESSION  
QR

Sheet serial  
Scan to start or join this  
sheet's tracked session.

Date \_\_\_\_\_ Session / group \_\_\_\_\_ Facilitator \_\_\_\_\_

Instruction + setup \_\_\_\_\_ Game time \_\_\_\_\_ Total session \_\_\_\_\_ Rules lookup \_\_\_\_\_

Test type: ☐ First game ☐ Repeated matchup ☐ Leader comparison ☐ Custom Deck ☐ Rules/components

**Player A**  
Name / ID \_\_\_\_\_  
Faction / Leader \_\_\_\_\_  
Deck \_\_\_\_\_  
Recommended? ☐ Yes ☐ Modified ☐ No  
Faction teaching card used? ☐ Yes ☐ No

**Player B**  
Name / ID \_\_\_\_\_  
Faction / Leader \_\_\_\_\_  
Deck \_\_\_\_\_  
Recommended? ☐ Yes ☐ Modified ☐ No  
Faction teaching card used? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Outcome and completion

First player: ☐ A ☐ B Winner: ☐ A ☐ B ☐ None Rounds \_\_\_\_\_ Battles \_\_\_\_\_

Ended by: ☐ Normal victory ☐ Concession ☐ Time ☐ Rules blocker ☐ Component/technical issue ☐ Other

Victory route: ☐ Final Territory ☐ Last Stand ☐ Peace Treaty ☐ Controlling Interest ☐ Special Operation ☐ Ritual ☐ Purification

Player ratings - circle 1 (poor) through 5 (excellent)

| Question             | A         | B         | Question                 | A         | B         |
|----------------------|-----------|-----------|--------------------------|-----------|-----------|
| Overall fun          | 1 2 3 4 5 | 1 2 3 4 5 | Pacing                   | 1 2 3 4 5 | 1 2 3 4 5 |
| Meaningful decisions | 1 2 3 4 5 | 1 2 3 4 5 | Battle tension           | 1 2 3 4 5 | 1 2 3 4 5 |
| Rules clarity        | 1 2 3 4 5 | 1 2 3 4 5 | Faction / Leader clarity | 1 2 3 4 5 | 1 2 3 4 5 |
| Table organization   | 1 2 3 4 5 | 1 2 3 4 5 | Would play again         | 1 2 3 4 5 | 1 2 3 4 5 |

v0.6.3 procedure checks

- ☐ Turn sequence stayed clear
- ☐ Opening selection → Territory arrangement → initiative caused confusion
- ☐ Setup placement vs movement / entering caused confusion
- ☐ Final Territory vs Last Stand caused confusion
- ☐ Pending battle / Terms / Onset caused confusion
- ☐ Defensive Edge / Tiebreak Roll caused confusion
- ☐ Front Line vs Position caused confusion
- ☐ Fall Back / retreat / withdrawal caused confusion

**What worked best?**

**What dragged or frustrated?**

**What required a ruling?**

**Best moment / hardest decision**

Detailed Observations

Battle and movement record

| # | Attacker | Territory / Position | Terms? | Result | Notable rule/card interaction |
|---|----------|----------------------|--------|--------|-------------------------------|
| 1 |          |                      |        |        |                               |
| 2 |          |                      |        |        |                               |
| 3 |          |                      |        |        |                               |
| 4 |          |                      |        |        |                               |
| 5 |          |                      |        |        |                               |
| 6 |          |                      |        |        |                               |

Did any of these occur?

- ☐ Winner clear long before the end
- ☐ Repetitive or low-stakes battles
- ☐ Player had no meaningful options
- ☐ Attacking felt consistently futile
- ☐ Territory / Asset loss snowballed too hard
- ☐ Additional victory felt solitary or irrelevant
- ☐ Card flow or Graveyard pressure broke down
- ☐ Rules, zones, or components interrupted play
- ☐ Starter Deck did not present its plan
- ☐ Opponent summary omitted needed information

|                                                                                                                               |                                                                                                                               |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <div>Most confusing rule, card, or timing window</div> <div></div> <div></div> <div></div> <div></div> <div></div>            | <div>Anything too strong, too weak, or automatic?</div> <div></div> <div></div> <div></div> <div></div> <div></div>           |
| <div>Did a faction procedure distract from the shared game?</div> <div></div> <div></div> <div></div> <div></div> <div></div> | <div>Did any printed aid fail to answer a routine question?</div> <div></div> <div></div> <div></div> <div></div> <div></div> |
| <div>Most important thing to investigate next</div> <div></div> <div></div> <div></div> <div></div> <div></div>               | <div>Other observations / exact wording remembered</div> <div></div> <div></div> <div></div> <div></div> <div></div>          |

Facilitator classification

- ☐ Rules defect
- ☐ Wording defect
- ☐ Teaching defect
- ☐ Component/layout defect
- ☐ Balance signal
- ☐ Technical defect
- ☐ No action yet



Military

**Aim:** Win battles, gain Command, and convert momentum into movement and control.  
**Resource:** Command, maximum 2. Gain 1 the first time each turn Military wins a battle.  
**Faction Actions:** None. Orders are Faction Abilities at their printed timings.  
**Victory:** Run the Gauntlet.  
**General:** attacks repeatedly and carries momentum forward.      **Commandant:** defends controlled ground and turns defensive wins into pressure.  
**Recommended first Leader:** General. **Starter:** Forward Doctrine.

FIRST-TURN PLAN

Establish your movement line, preserve a useful Gambit, and look for the first battle that can begin the Command loop.

OPPONENT SUMMARY

Track Command. Military can add movement, modify battle totals, extend a retreat, or advance its Front Line after a win. Invasion can enlarge an attacking Reserve and Tactic limit, but its unused movement ends when a pending battle is created.

Diplomats

**Aim:** Offer Terms, ratify different Proposals, and reshape battles through agreement or refusal.  
**Resource:** Influence, 0-10; begin with 1.  
**Procedure:** Offer Terms during a pending battle before Onset. Use Leverage before dice after refused Terms.  
**Victory:** Peace Treaty after five different Proposals are ratified.  
**Ambassador:** gains card flow from accepted Terms.      **Senator:** risks larger Stakes and preserves Influence after setbacks.  
**Recommended first Leader:** Ambassador. **Starter:** Open Channels.

FIRST-TURN PLAN

Build enough Influence to make refusal costly, then offer a Proposal whose accepted and refused results both advance your plan.

OPPONENT SUMMARY

Read the Proposal before accepting or refusing. Accepted Terms prevent the battle; refusal proceeds to Onset. Newly ratified Proposals grant Influence. Détente rewards acceptance only when the Proposal was already ratified when offered.

Financiers

**Aim:** Build Capital and Treasury value, buy Deeds, and combine ownership with territorial pressure.

**Resource:** Capital; begin with 2.

**Faction Actions:** Treasury, Deed purchase, Play the Market, and Hostile Takeover during Denouement.

**Ability:** Subsidize before dice. Financial Capacity may permit one Action in Opening and one in Denouement when one is a Financier Faction Action.

**Victory:** Own the Deeds to every Territory through Controlling Interest.

**Banker:** uses cards as controlled collateral.                      **Executive:** converts offensive Occupation into ownership and control.

**Recommended first Leader:** Executive. **Starter:** Hostile Expansion.

OPPONENT SUMMARY

Capital, Treasury, and Deeds are public. Financial Capacity may give both Action phases, but at least one Action must be a Financier Faction Action. Deed ownership does not itself equal Territory control.

Intelligence

**Aim:** Complete Missions, gain Intel and Operation Progress, and prepare a Special Operation.

**Resources:** Intel and Operation Progress.

**Faction Actions:** Start, complete, or abort a Mission; start or complete a Special Operation, all during Denouement.

**Abilities:** Surveillance, Interference, Fieldcraft, and Mission Control at their stated timings.

**Victory:** Complete a ready Special Operation.

**Ranger:** uses Fieldcraft and terrain knowledge.                      **Spymaster:** chains Missions through Mission Control.

**Recommended first Leader:** Ranger. **Starter:** Field Operations.

OPPONENT SUMMARY

Mission identity is hidden, but Intel and Operation Progress are public. Intelligence may inspect and interfere with a face-down Gambit and later face-down Tactics. Replacements do not create a new information window.

Mystics

**Aim:** Complete three Rites, unlock faction abilities, then complete the Ritual of Ascendance.

**Progression:** Three public Rites; no resource tracker.

**Faction Actions:** Begin a Rite or begin the Ritual during Denouement. Nature's Altar may permit Begin a Rite during Opening.

**Victory:** Initiate and win a battle while the three Ritual cards remain bound.

**Alchemist:** replaces deliberate sacrifice with card flow.    **Spirit Walker:** protects Rite and Ritual progress after a loss.

**Recommended first Leader:** Spirit Walker. **Starter:** Unbroken Circle.

FIRST-TURN PLAN

Choose the Rite that best fits your opening cards. Keep Arcane value available if the Spirit Walker may need to prevent interruption.

OPPONENT SUMMARY

Completed Rites and face-up bound cards are public. The Spirit Walker may sacrifice Arcane value 1, 2, 3, or 4 according to progress. Nature's Altar requires token presence to begin and control at completion timing for its same-turn exception.

Inquisition

**Aim:** Build Conviction, move opposing cards permanently into the Graveyard, and use Purge to remove options.

**Resource:** Conviction, maximum 4.

**Faction Action:** Purge during Opening or Denouement. A Purge Action permits one Action in each phase when one is Purge.

**Abilities:** Condemnation, Blasphemy, Final Judgment, and Relentless Pursuit.

**Victory:** Purification when the opponent cannot make the normal start-of-turn draw because both Draw Pile and Discard Pile are empty.

**Grand Inquisitor:** converts wins into discounted      **Witch Hunter:** punishes failed attacks with pursuit. Purges.

**Recommended first Leader:** Grand Inquisitor. **Starter:** Final Judgment.

OPPONENT SUMMARY

Opposing Tactics normally go to the Graveyard in battles against Inquisition. Track Conviction before playing Arcane cards or attacking the Witch Hunter. Martyrdom does not prevent a loss, but it can send cards remaining in the winner's Reserve to the Graveyard.

# Active-Player Markers

**Purpose:** The marker tracks only whose turn it is and the shared turn sequence. It does not track battle initiative, priority, Actions remaining, or the attacker.

Gauntlet v0.6.3

YOUR TURN

CAPTURE - DRAW - OPENING  
MOVEMENT - DENOUEMENT - CLEANUP

Take one Action during Opening or Denouement.  
Pass this marker after Cleanup.

FOLD

Gauntlet v0.6.3

YOUR TURN

CAPTURE - DRAW - OPENING  
MOVEMENT - DENOUEMENT - CLEANUP

Take one Action during Opening or Denouement.  
Pass this marker after Cleanup.

Gauntlet v0.6.3

YOUR TURN

CAPTURE - DRAW - OPENING  
MOVEMENT - DENOUEMENT - CLEANUP

Take one Action during Opening or Denouement.  
Pass this marker after Cleanup.

FOLD

Gauntlet v0.6.3

YOUR TURN

CAPTURE - DRAW - OPENING  
MOVEMENT - DENOUEMENT - CLEANUP

Take one Action during Opening or Denouement.  
Pass this marker after Cleanup.

For repeated use, tape the inside edges after folding or place a small binder clip at the base.

## What Changed in Gauntlet v0.6.3

**Status:** Release candidate — not published

**Baseline:** Published v0.6.2

**Release tracker:** #528

This handout explains the v0.6.3 changes that materially affect table play or how cards are read. v0.6.2 remains the published playtest edition until the v0.6.3 publication cutover is completed.

## At a glance

1. **Setup now starts you on the Gauntlet.** Your token begins on the Territory at your own end; setup placement is not movement and does not count as entering.
2. **Opening selection happens before Territory arrangement.** Draw four, discard one face up, keep three, then arrange your Territories with that information known. Roll for first player last.
3. **Running the Gauntlet has two equal normal routes.** Capture the opponent's final Territory or win their Last Stand.
4. **A separate movement sequence can force a Last Stand before final-Territory capture.** Prior control of the final Territory is not required.
5. **Deck means the constructed ordinary-card set.** Draw Pile means the shuffled in-play pile. The term *Playable Deck* is retired in v0.6.3 player-facing text.
6. **Battle is no longer a card-effect heading.** Dual-role cards print **Gambit/Tactic**.
7. **Asset is the only banked-card heading.** The former *Activate* heading is retired, and cards with Asset effects normally have an inherent Bank Action.
8. **Repeated card procedures have moved into shared rules.** Cards are shorter because standard banking, directly permitted card use, effect-granted movement, additional Tactics, Sanctions, Asset Removal, Bind cleanup, reveal interference, copied/repeated effects, and battles ending without a winner are now governed centrally.
9. **Routine numeric effects use compact shorthand.** Examples include +1 Card, +1 Action, +1 Tactic, Retreat +1, Command = 2, and Advance Front Line 1.
10. **The complete 128-card pool received a production-size text audit.** All 128 v0.6.3 candidate cards pass the normal production fitter without emergency text fitting.

## Setup

Prepare faction components that can modify the Deck first. Shuffle the remaining Deck to form the Draw Pile, draw four, discard one face up, and keep three. Then secretly arrange your three Territories. Form and reveal the Gauntlet, place each Player Token on the Territory at that player's own end, and roll for first player only after both players have completed opening selection and Territory arrangement.

Your opening Hand and opening discard may inform Territory order. Initiative may not.

## Running the Gauntlet

You immediately run the Gauntlet and win when you either capture the Territory at your opponent's end or win your opponent's Last Stand.

A legal immediate-capture effect can win on the final Territory. After a battle forces the opponent beyond their own end, an effect that grants a separate legal movement sequence can let you Advance beyond the Gauntlet and initiate the Last Stand immediately, even if the final Territory still faces the opponent.

# Reading cards

## Effect headings

- **Action** — play from Hand by taking an Action at a legal phase or timing.
- **Asset** — banked-card effect; the card normally has an inherent Bank Action.
- **Gambit** — available only as a Gambit.
- **Tactic** — available only as a Tactic.
- **Gambit/Tactic** — the same effect is available in either role.

The old **Battle** and **Activate** headings are retired in v0.6.3.

## Shared procedures now omitted from cards

Expect shorter text where shared rules already establish the routine procedure. This includes default Asset banking, directly permitted card procedures not costing another Action, movement granted outside an existing sequence beginning a new movement sequence, additional-Tactic handling, Sanction expiration, default Bind cleanup, reveal-stage interference, rerolls using the new result, applying/repeating another effect, and cleanup when a battle ends without a winner.

Specific exceptions remain printed on the card.

## Battle habit

Before committing battle cards, check the contested Territory and your Asset Bank. This is a recommended play habit, not another battle step or timing window.

## Card-text revision

The v0.6.3 card pass applies the new shared language across all 128 cards and then uses bespoke compression only where needed. **Protracted Siege** includes an expressly adopted mechanics revision: its banked Asset can directly prevent capture, while its Gambit/Tactic mode creates the delayed Overlay. Other wording changes remain governed by their finalized v0.6.3 card text and shared rules.

## What remains familiar

The six factions, twelve Leaders, turn sequence, Gambit/Reserve/Tactic battle structure, Front Line concept, faction resources, and faction-specific victory systems remain based on v0.6.2 except where a v0.6.3 source expressly changes them. Specific cards and components still override general rules when they directly address the situation.